

Family pride: Jaismine with her parents, Joginder Kaur and Jaiveer Lamboria. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

serious bacterial infection had appeared around May 25 or 26. For 15 to 20 days the family could not work out what was wrong. The fever kept returning, sometimes reaching 102 or 103 degrees.

She tried to train through it, but eventually had to be admitted to hospital. Doctors finally identified the bacterial infection. She was put on antibiotics for 14 days.

By the time she started to train again on July 1, the Commonwealth Games were barely weeks away. "I had maybe 20-22 days to recover," she says.

The illness had also wrecked her physically. She competes at 57kg and normally has to cut weight to make the weight class. This time she arrived at the Games weighing around 55kg because she had lost so much during the illness. "I wasn't sure how I would go for the Commonwealth. I didn't know if it could be fixed."

For perhaps the first time in her career, Jaismine entered a major tournament knowing that she was not at her best. She had to find another way. "I think I was about 70 percent of my full fitness in Glasgow. I couldn't attack every round at my 100 percent. I couldn't have fought nine minutes of every bout the same way," she says.

That became the lesson of Glasgow.

Having spent the previous two years learning to control what happened inside her head, she had to learn to control what was happening inside her body. "I had to pace myself. I had to conserve energy. I understood that I couldn't fight how I would if I was fully fit," she says.

From that perspective, Jaismine says she couldn't have performed any better than she did. "I developed the mindset to understand I need to focus on what is in my hands. I got the most out of those nine minutes in the ring."



Long-term goal

The Commonwealth Games gold might have made her one of India's stars from Glasgow, but back in Bhiwani, Jaismine smiles as she admits things haven't changed all that much with her family. "Everyone is of course happy that I've got a gold, especially since it was my uncle's dream that he couldn't fulfil, but no one is treating me any differently than anyone else. I'm just another girl in the house. I haven't got any gift or anything. Just the *churma*!" she says.

She isn't looking for any prolonged celebration either.

Jaismine doesn't see Glasgow as the final destination in her journey. She's already looking towards the next big competitions of the year. Although she isn't part of the Asian

Games squad, she's got her mind on the Boxing World Cup finals in Uzbekistan and at next year's World Championships, which will be an Olympic qualification event.

Preparation begins now. "I want to perform well at the 2028 Olympics but that is two years away. My first target is to get my body back to the level it was before I fell sick. I still have several weeks to get back to that level. I can't lose a day of training," she says.

She knows the journey to Los Angeles will have its ups and downs but she is ready for the challenge. "There are going to be many tests for me. But I've learned from every competition I've competed in. I'm going to use them to become better and better. I want to see how good I can become," she says.

